

The Deccan Traps

Location Mostly Maharashtra, Gujarat, and Madhya Pradesh provinces, India

The Deccan Traps form one of the largest volcanic features on Earth, a vast area of multiple steplike layers of solidified basalt released about 65 million years ago. In places, the basalt is more than 6,600 ft (2,000 m) thick and covers 190,000 square miles (500,000 square km). One theory proposes that the eruptions were caused by the Réunion hotspot, a mantle plume that once lay under South Asia.

Sigiriya

Location Central Province, Sri Lanka

The near-vertical sides of Sigiriya, or Lion Rock, rise abruptly 590 ft (180 m) from the forest below, with the ruins of an ancient royal palace on its flattened summit. The rock is the solidified magma plug of a volcano whose cone has long since been eroded. As the magma in its vent cooled, the minerals crystallized at different rates, so the composition of Sigiriya changes with height.

Seongsan Ilchulbong

Location Off the east coast of Jeju, South Korea

This World Heritage Site is a tuff cone—made of compacted volcanic rock—that rises from the sea close to the South Korean coast. The sides of the former volcano tower 590 ft (180 m) above the water. Seongsan Ilchulbong was created by a volcanic eruption on the seafloor about 5,000 years ago. The cliffs rise to a circular summit rim, which encloses a crater—an almost perfect bowl 295 ft (90 m) deep and 1,480 ft (450 m) across.

